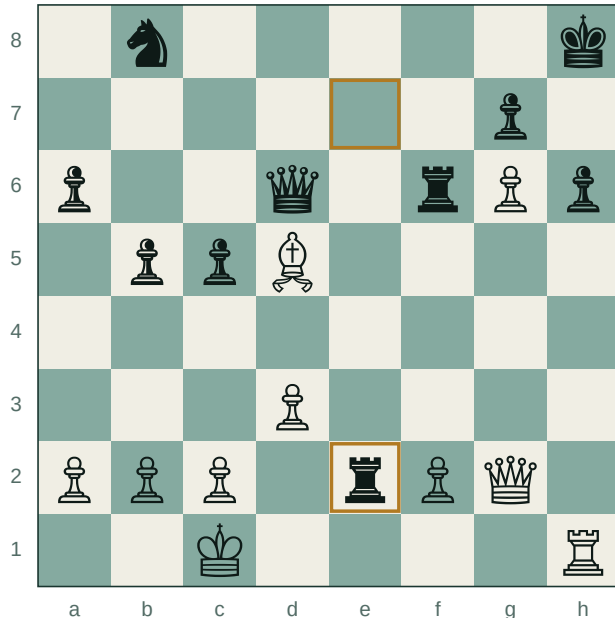


Mate in three: White, move 26

Mate in three

White to move



Previous move: 25...Rxe2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26. Rxh6+ gxh6 27. g7+ Kh7 28. g8=Q#

26.Rxh6+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the pawn on h6. Recorded reply: **26...gxh6**.

27.g7+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **27...Kh7**.

28.g8=Q# Mate: queen on g8 gives check; Black has no legal reply. The pawn becomes a queen.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h7. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Queen on g8. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not stop at a promising check. The final mating position must still be legal after every intervening move.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Longer mating lines require accurate visualization. Track the king's square, opened lines, and every sacrificed piece through the entire sequence.

HOW TO LOOK

Work backward from a mating pattern, then calculate forward with the opponent choosing the strongest defense.

The defending king is on h8. Absolute pin: pawn on h6.